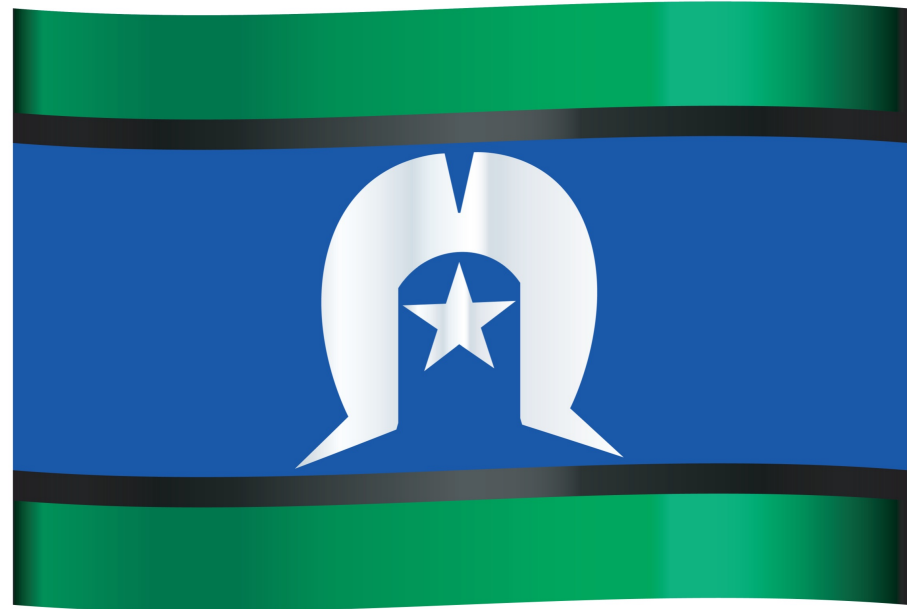


A photograph of two women standing outdoors in a grassy area with trees in the background. They are both smiling and looking at a book held by the woman on the left. The woman on the right is holding a green folder. The image is framed by a large, semi-transparent circular overlay.

Professional Learning Online

**Secondary Education · Online Session 1: Autism,
Sensory and Ways of Thinking**

Acknowledgement of Country



First Nations people are advised that this workshop may contain images and voices of people who are no longer with us.



Taking part online

Take part in whatever way works for you today.

Cameras optional

Turn your camera on or off as you need.

Many ways to join in

Chat, reactions, speaking, private notes or passing all count.

Breakout rooms

Small groups for some activities. You can ask to stay in the main room.

Look after yourself

Move, stretch or step away and come back whenever you need to.

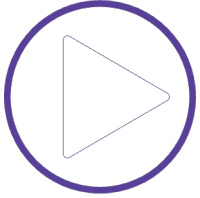
Use initials or roles only in the chat and in breakout rooms.

Think about your students



Bring two or three students to mind, ideally students who are quite different from each other.

- What are you here for?
- What would you like to understand better?
- What strengths, interests or moments of connection should stay visible?



Student voice



What did you notice?



- What stayed with you?
- What would you like to understand more deeply?

Neurodiversity affirming

**Differences
are not
deficits**

Acknowledging
different ways of
knowing, doing, being
and belonging

All people have
strengths and
experience challenges

There is no right or
wrong way to think,
learn or behave

Everyone experiences
and interacts with the
world differently

The social model

Use an environment-first lens:

Look for barriers in places, tasks, routines and expectations

Ask what can change around the student

Include the student's communication and experience when judging access

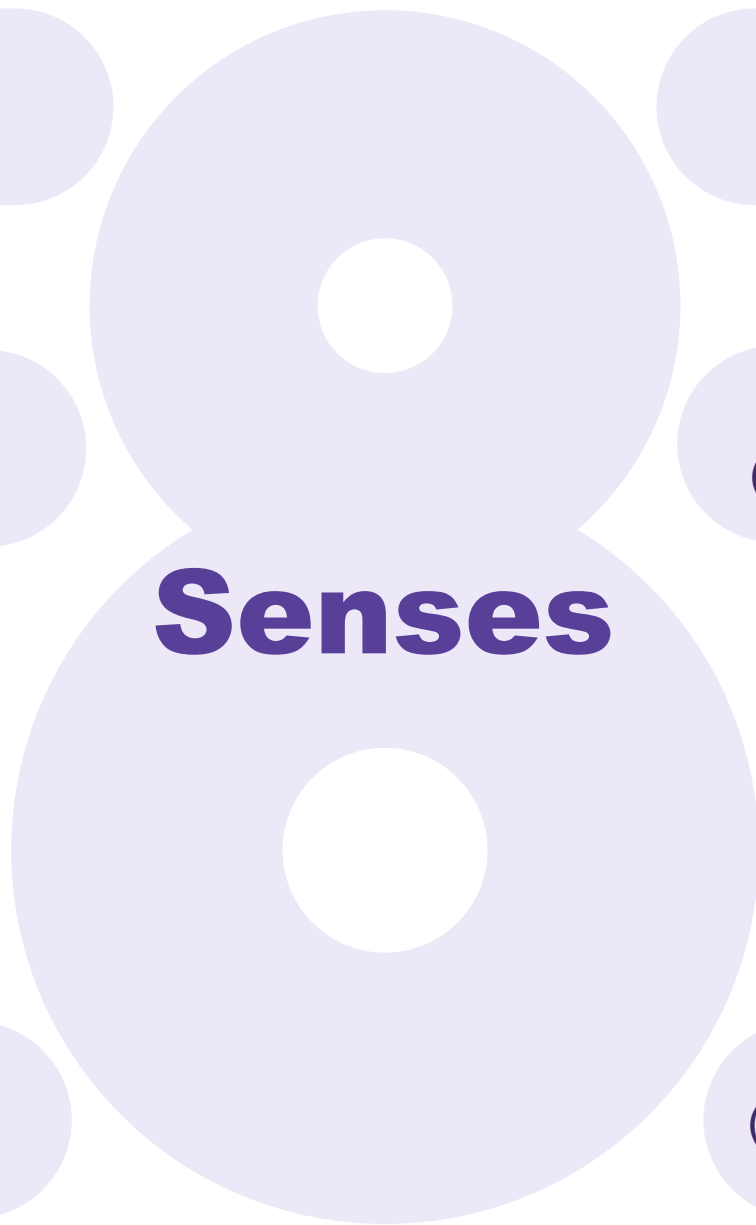
Review whether the change makes participation more workable

Autism as difference

Dynamic disability

A student's access and support needs may change with the task, environment, relationships and available capacity.

Fluctuating capacity



Senses



Touch



Smell



Vision

Proprioception
(Sense of body in space)



Gustatory
(Oral sensations)

Vestibular (Balance)



Hearing

Interoception
(Sense of internal
body signals)



Sensory joy and stimming

Sensory experience can include pleasure, connection and regulation as well as discomfort or overload.

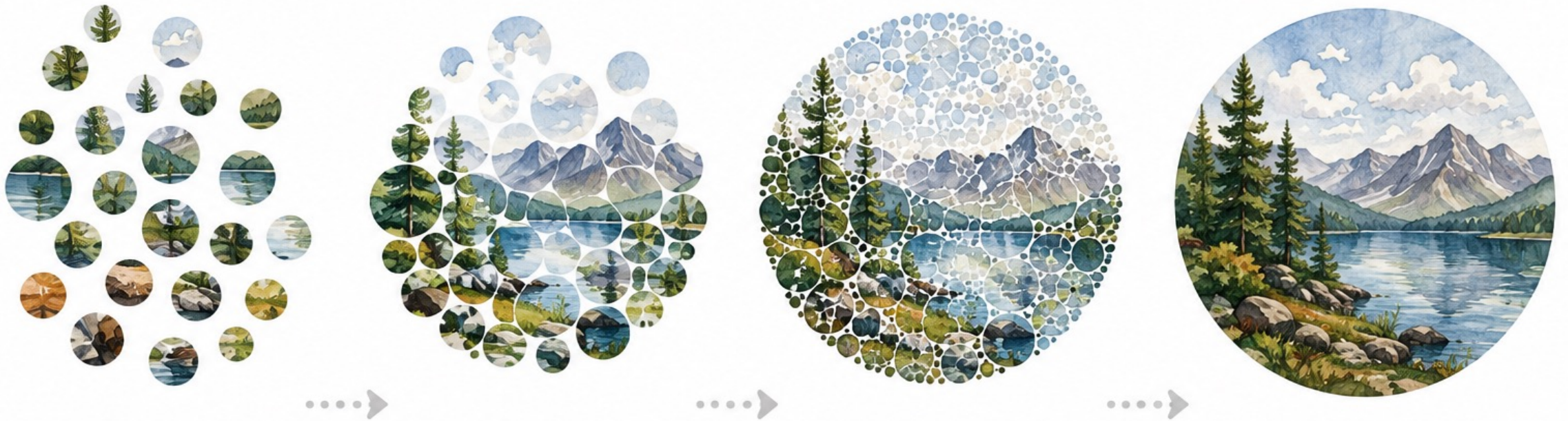
1 Notice sensory joy

2 Recognise stimming and authentic expression

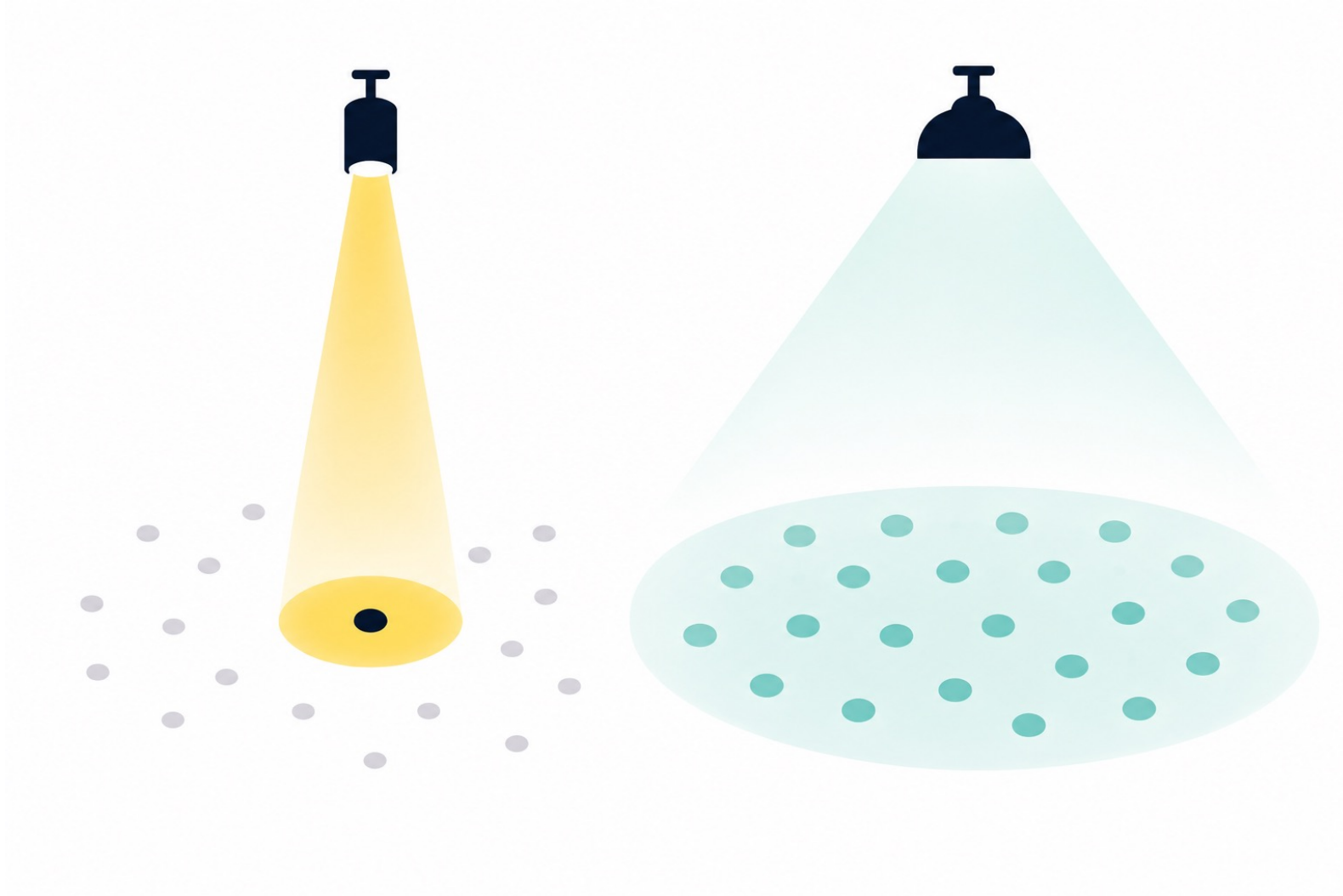
3 Avoid treating difference as disruption by default

4 Ask what students want others to understand

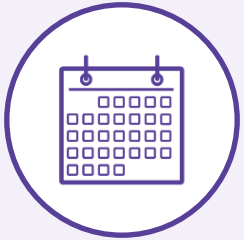
The Detail-First Brain



The Deep Focus Brain



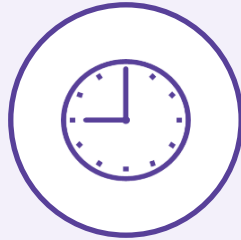
Executive Functioning



Planning



Organisation



**Time
management**



Working memory



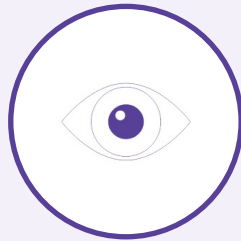
Meta-cognition
(thinking about our own
thinking)



**Emotional
regulation**



Flexibility



Attention



Task initiation



Persistence

Making sense of what's happening inside

Interoception

Understanding our body's internal signals

Temperature

Hunger

Thirst

Do I need the bathroom?



Alexithymia

Difficulty identifying and describing emotions and feelings

Am I excited or am I anxious?

Is crying always sadness?

What is my friend feeling?

Sensory activity

Choose one familiar routine in a class or across the school day. What sensory demands does the environment or task create, and what options could increase access or choice?

- 1 Name the routine without identifying a student or school.
- 2 List environmental and task demands before listing student responses.
- 3 Add possible options, including ways a student might communicate what helps.
- 4 Mark each option as a question to explore rather than an assumed solution.

Before the next session

Notice one familiar routine with the students you have in mind.

What supports them

What helps access, connection or joy in that routine?

What adds demand

What seems to make it harder, and when?

What you do not know yet

Write it down as a question to explore.

Bring your notes to Online Session 2.